Educazione all'architettura per la cittadinanza cosmopolita

Cinque storie, due domande e una direttiva

Massimo Santanicchia Iceland University of the Arts
massimo@lhi.is

Questo articolo spiega come il concetto di cittadinanza cosmopolita può essere utilizzato per rafforzare la formazione degli architetti. Lo fa attraverso cinque storie che ampliano i ruoli sociali degli architetti, ponendo due domande che ogni progetto di architettura e design dovrebbe porsi, e suggerendo una nuova direttiva professionale da aggiungere alle undici esistenti che regolano l'educazione in architettura in Europa.

Architettura, Educazione, Cosmopolita, Cittadinanza, Cura

This article explains how the concept of cosmopolitan citizenship can be used to reinvigorate architectural education. It does so by illustrating five stories regarding possible architects' societal roles, by raising two questions to be addressed in the design studio, and by proposing one new professional qualification directive to be added to the eleven that constitute the EU Directive on architectural education.

Architecture, Education, Cosmopolitan, Citizenship, Care

M. Santanicchia Orcid 0000-0002-6936-8087

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Architectural education for cosmopolitan citizenship

The question of "how will we live together?" constitutes the theme of the 17th Venice Architecture Biennale. Its curator, Hashim Sarkis, states that "we call on architects to imagine spaces in which we can generously live together" (La Biennale di Venezia, 2020); to do so, architecture has to "make us more aware individuals; help us become citizens, not just consumers" (La Biennale di Venezia, 2020). These reflections prompt the query: how can schools of architecture educate their students to become citizens?

The answer to this question is the object of this paper, based both on my personal experience as an educator in architecture at the Iceland University of the Arts and as a researcher on architectural pedagogies in the Nordic Baltic Academy of Architecture NBAA (Santanicchia, 2018; 2019a; 2019b; NBAA, 2020). Five stories and two questions are therefore presented to invite each school of architecture to envision new architects' societal roles, to educate future professionals with the skills and behaviours necessary for becoming not only citizens but cosmopolitan citizens. The ultimate scope of this paper is to influence the current EU Directive on architectural education (EUR-Lex, 2020) by posing one more directive specifically dedicated to the social responsibility of architects. An architectural education for cosmopolitan citizenship creates the conditions for students to work collaboratively, developing professional skills, behaviours, and attitudes to imagine spaces in which we can generously live together (Santanicchia, 2020a).

Pedagogies for cosmopolitan citizenship

Design and citizenship are indissolubly linked together. Milton Glaser's words "good design is good citizenship" (Resnick, 2016, p. 12) constitute both a statement and a sense of purpose for each good designer. In the introduction of the book *Citizens Designers: Perspective on Design Responsibility*, Steven Heller states that "a designer must be professionally, culturally, and socially responsible for the impact his or her design has on citizenry" (Heller, Vienne, 2003, p. x). To do so, design schools have to aim to educate not only skilled professionals but empathic, active citizens. "To educate is to foster the development of judgement, personal initiative, and the adoption of values. Good designers are good citizens, socially responsible people" (Frascara & Noël, 2012, p. 50).

I believe that good architecture shares the same goal: to educate good cosmopolitan citizens, that is, world citizen architects who have both competencies and behaviours

to co-design how we can generously live together (Santanicchia, 2020a).

Reflecting upon and imagining how we live together is the foundation of any theory of education, any method and practice of teaching. Each pedagogy offers in fact a "particular version and vision of a civic life, the future, and how we might construct representations of ourselves, others, and our physical and social environment" (Giroux, 2011, p. 71). Paulo Freire states that education should empower people, helping them "to be in the world", which implies both "being *with* the world" and "*with* others" ([1997], 2007, p. 33). This means helping them develop self-confidence, empathy, and the understanding that humanity shares a common destiny.

In the schools' part of Nordic and Baltic Academy of Architecture NBAA (NBAA, 2020), education is centred in the physical and social space of the design studio: its main pedagogical tool. The design studio is viewed as an asset, but it can also become a threat to architects' education at the moment it disconnects students and teachers from "being in the world", at the moment it becomes a secluded space more concerned with spatial innovation than care for the Others (Santanicchia, 2018; 2019a; 2019b).

Pedagogies for cosmopolitan citizenship can be implemented when the boundaries of the design studio are transgressed physically and mentally, when real forms of engagement are created amongst the students and teachers working together (Santanicchia, 2018; 2019a; 2019b). When critical thinking, social awareness of the state of the world – its problems, injustices, and possibilities – and activism engage with solutions, they become the purpose of education (Giroux, 1980) and the purpose of the design studio (Santanicchia, 2020a: 2020b). In order to truly care for the Others, we must act as a cosmopolitan citizen, as "the person whose allegiance is to the worldwide community of human beings" (Nussbaum, 2010, p. 154). This will help develop a universal belief in building a collective, civic, communal future in which no one is excluded. A cosmopolitan citizenship education theory starts with an acute awareness of the state of the world and with the intention to care for Others (Santanicchia, 2020a; 2020b). It is therefore schools' and teachers' responsibility to create the conditions necessary to transform design studios into social platforms that are receptive to students' own interests and different backgrounds and that value collaboration as a fundamental design tool, understanding that creativity is never a private matter. A civically engaged design studio is a place for developing a professional ethos, a critical understanding of the world, a place for cooper-



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ation among different stakeholders; a place to reach out and connect to society; a place where students, teachers, and outsiders can solve problems together and imagine a common future in a respectful, caring – yet critical – spirit. The ultimate goal of a cosmopolitan citizenship design studio is to widen and maximise students' and teachers' agency while developing the capacity to care and the courage to act together responsibly to improve the world. Five stories have been identified as essential to expanding architects' social mission (Santanicchia, 2020b). These stories describe architects as:

Dissident intellectuals capable of challenging the status quo, norms and stereotypes, and able to use the design process to reveal social and environmental injustices and expose them to a larger audience.

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Ethical professionals capable of operating in increasingly multicultural societies, representing and advocating for different interests in the design process, understanding that each artefact, object or service made has a social and ecological value. Making, after all, is always a political matter and as such concerns us all.
Engaged storytellers capable of communicating with the world by using the language of design. Each project is a story, an occasion to excite; each project is a way of knowing, sharing concerns, building communities, and imagining how we can live together harmoniously.
Co-creative partners capable of understanding that architecture is a social practice and that creativity is never a private matter. Each project constitutes an occasion to redefine the boundaries of the discipline, to forge new ways for cooperating and collaborating and to image how to live together.
Carers of the common good capable of understanding that humanity is bound to a common destiny and able to make choices and act based on a common good. Designers have the societal responsibility to care for the people involved in the design process: for those who build it, those who use it, and those whom it impacts. Architecture after all is never a private matter.
In order to activate these five social roles, two fundamental questions must resonate in the space of the design studio and through the education of an architect:
What are the politics of your design?
What is the design of your politics?
Politics must be understood as the potential capacity of a group – the way we want to live together – and as such, it has to be inclusive of different voices and interests. These complex questions can be explored through five auxiliary ones which aim to activate students' critical thinking, social awareness, activism, and ultimately their mission as cosmopolitan citizenship architects.

1. Are critical questions asked in the design studio?
Education is not an innocent exercise but an activity that has something at stake and that occurs in a set of political and social conditions (Smith, 2012, p. 5). As such, it has implications within and beyond the boundaries of the design studio. The design studio is a place to question and to imagine a new world. Dialogues are the fundamental tool in the design studio: "without dialogue there is no communication, and without communication there can be no true education" (Freire [1970], 1993, p. 66). Each project is an occasion for engaging in dialogue and raising critical questions to advance the design

project and question our roles in the design studio. Each project is an occasion to be a dissident intellectual re-imagining how we live together, challenging norms to work for a better world. To do so, each project must answer the following questions: To what issue does it respond? Why is this issue important? How does it respond to the issue? Whose interests does it serve and whose does it not? Who owns it? And finally, why is the project important? Good questions should empower and encourage, reveal potentialities, challenge assumptions, and utilise research, knowledge, and imagination to fight injustices and to care for the Other.

2. Is the design studio open to the diversity of the world? Each school of architecture is a community of learners. Good and healthy communities are vibrant and diverse, disclosing multiple possibilities for knowing and understanding the world (Harding, 2015). Architectural and design research can serve democratic goals by enabling different voices to join the conversation, especially those most marginalised. In order to educate ethical professionals, students and educators must learn to see the world from different viewpoints to formulate inclusivity in the design process, decolonising its curricula by acknowledging the importance of feminism, queer theory, postcolonialism, posthumanism, and cultural and indigenous studies. A plurality of sources of knowledge, perspectives, and methodologies enriches the design process and its outcomes. This expands the understanding of the spatial and social implications of architecture and enlarges its scope and goals; it creates more profound meanings for what architects can do; and it incites architects to work more empathetically for social and environmental justice for the care of the Other.

3. Does the design studio encourage collaboration among students, teachers, and the Other?

"As a classroom community, our capacity to generate excitement is deeply affected by our interest in one another, in hearing one another's voices, in recognizing one another's presence" (hooks, 1994, p. 8). The design studio is a place for socialisation, a place to discuss our position in the world, a place "to see the world not as a static reality, but as a reality in process, in transformation" (Freire [1970], 1993, p. 54). It is therefore important that we realise who is part of this community and who is excluded, and that we ask what can be done to promote a more inclusive architectural education. In the design studio we must surpass individual egos, move together towards a common ecological and social

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consciousness, and realise that learning is a collaborative process and creativity requires thinking, imagining, and acting together. Being co-creative partners means listening to different voices, especially those who have no means to be heard, and practicing consilience, linking together principles and people from different sources (Sinni, 2019). This develops epistemological qualities such as openness and curiosity, but also moral qualities such as respect, humility, trust, compassion, and benevolence. Being co-creative partners means activating the social and political role of architects; it fuels collective creativity, the confidence and the courage to engage in dialogue and form community. It also means the ability to work as a group that assumes moral responsibility and cares for the impact of architectural performance on society, on natural systems, and on the Other.

4. Is the design studio engaging with its community?
Architecture would not exist without its social, cultural, political, economic, and ecological context. Architectural research means understanding how the complexity of the context is the basis of knowledge-formation in the design process. A place-based architectural education links academia and practice, schools and communities, by working together on issues of common concern, and by developing occasions for live projects (Harriss, Widder, 2014). A design studio honours the strong bonds humans have with their own places and at the same time acknowledges

that we are also part of something bigger, something truly great and truly common: the world. Each design project constitutes an opportunity for engaging with the community and the world, an occasion for telling a story of how to live together harmoniously. An engaged storyteller understands cogent issues and reveals them using the design process as a vehicle for communication. In a time of growing nationalisms, xenophobic attitudes, and exclusionary forces, which impair the formation of a global vision, storytelling has the power to form a common understanding and must be a leading approach in the design studio and beyond.

5. Does the design studio lead to action?
Engaging with real people and circumstances during the formative years through developing community-based design, forms of urban advocacy, and other participatory design processes, creates conditions for students to act with care and social responsibility (Harriss, Widder, 2014). Action means extending dialogues beyond the design studio into the real world in order to change it. Actions can also be dissident, insurgent, and obstructive, directed to a perceived injustice. Students in architecture need to know that professionals always have a choice, even if only to refuse to build: refusal is more than a simple act of not doing—it's an opening up to the possibility of doing differently (Anderson et al., 2017). Refusal may be the most radical act we can perform as citizens. Design studios have to act as a social platform to equip students technically, methodologically, and intellectually to be carers of the common good, exploring collectively how we can live together harmoniously, understanding that each student's project is the beginning of the process "to be in the world" and care for it.

This reflection on architectural education in the Nordic Baltic context would not be complete without attempting to advance policy for architectural education and suggest one more directive to be added to the eleven professional qualification directives as part of the EU Directive 85/384/EEC (EUR-Lex, 2020).
12. An understanding that architecture is about how we live together; therefore, an architect has the responsibility as cosmopolitan citizen to care for the Other, for the global community of human beings and earthlings.
This directive aims to expand the societal role of the architect beyond knowledge and skill acquisition. It is about fostering the behaviour necessary to assume the responsibility of carer so that spaces in which we can gen-

erously live together can be conceived, imagined, and discussed in our society. Each design project is a story that reveals present conditions and imagines possible futures; each story is narrated by using the universal language of design comprised of drawings, models, diagrams, installations, webpages, events, and writing itself. Each story is a project that can regenerate our interests in each other and the world (Santanicchia, 2020a).

This article has presented five stories and two fundamental questions, leading up to one directive – "to be in the world" – to support pedagogies for cosmopolitan citizenship. Architects are not only spatial explorers but political agents, people capable of using the wondrousness of architecture to actively engage with issues of local and global concern and to contribute to their solution. The critical questions of "what are the politics of my design?" and "what is the design of my politics?" are fundamental for any work of design. Becoming cosmopolitan citizen architects means including the Other, future generations, and unrepresented voices in the design process for social and ecological justice, learning to make ethical design decisions grounded in their social and environmental context and equally influenced by the understanding of their local and global implications.

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